



Wrong Medicine

Students in the state's six medical colleges may face an uncertain future if MCI goes ahead with its threat of derecognition

The annual visit of Medical Council of India (MCI) team to Bihar is a gathering of powerful people, where among the few things accomplished is a group photograph, in which representatives from the state are mostly seen not relishing the goings on. The reason for their discomfort is the pathetic state of the six medical colleges in the state and their apprehensions whether MCI will give them enough time to set things right.

This script has been repeated year after year. It was in October 2006 that the council had last visited the state and given the medical colleges "reasonable time" to put their house in order, failing which the colleges could be derecognised. Most medical colleges were severely short of faculty, with the Patna Medical College Hospital leading the pack. Expectedly, the state may see a replay of these events when the MCI team comes calling in March this year.

The reason: almost 20 per cent posts of senior teachers are still lying vacant in the state's six medical colleges, more than the permissible 16 per cent, according to the council's standards. "Such a situation has arisen due to the previous regimes' failure to grant promotions to teachers in time.

Though we are now recruiting teachers on contract basis, senior level vacancies still exist, and they cannot be filled in a short span of time," says state Health Minister, Chandra Mohan Rai.

Worse still, a number of teachers have left or are planning to leave for greener pastures. "There is a way out," says Dr Ajay Kumar, convener of the Bihar State Health Service Association (BSHSA). He feels the imple-

PROTESTING: MBBS students with Chief Minister Nitish Kumar (top); agitations against the administration



Most medical colleges are woefully short of teachers with a number of them having left their jobs for greener pastures.

mentation of the Dynamic Assured Career Promotion Scheme, aimed at providing appraisals which are due for years, is the only way of ending the shortage of teachers.

The Government, though, is working on another strategy. "The Health Department has initiated steps to reappoint retired medical college professors (below 65 years) on a one-year contract, subject to renewal," the minister said. Though MCI had earlier refused to acknowledge any ad hoc recruitment,

Rai is hopeful that he will be able to "persuade" the council.

It was only a few years ago that the council had threatened to derecognise medical colleges in Patna, Darbhanga and Bhagalpur due to the government's failure to address the problems of infrastructure and shortage of teaching staff. While this never happened and MCI agreed to give Bihar another chance, the threat still exists. "We cannot take MCI's threat lightly particularly after its refusal to issue Certificates of Continuance to 60 odd medical colleges in the country," said a senior member of BSHSA.

Moreover, the proposed MCI visit comes at a time when the present regime has floated a proposal to double the number of seats in the state's medical colleges. Not only this, plans are now afoot to set up new colleges in Patna, Betia, Nalanda and Madhepura. The task for the council is now cut out. It has to assess the infrastructure availability and the bench strength of the teachers—a problem area—before taking a decision on recommending a letter of intent to this effect. The government, thus, stands to lose face on the issue. state Health Secretary Deepak Kumar adds. "If there are anomalies and deficiencies, we are willing to admit it. We are trying to put things right. The process will take time," he says. The state's 2,000 medical students may have to keep their fingers crossed for the moment.

by Amitabh Srivastava